*PREPARING FOR THE CHALLENGES OF A BILINGUAL TEACHER IN TEACHING ENGLISH AS A FOREIGN/SECOND LANGUAGE

Abel M. Cadias, LPT, Phd
Affiliated International High School of National Chengchi University
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Bilingual Education can be traced back in the 19th century, and it was aimed at supporting two powerful languages in educating the elites. In the mid-20th century, bilingual education was used to cater both language minorities and language majorities in North America. With this development towards bilingual education, two programs emerged: immersion and transitional. The goal of an "immersion bilingual education" is to introduce a second language to learners gradually as they move up to the next grade level. On the other hand, the "transitional bilingual education" was conceptualized in the U.S. to use the minority language at the early levels of students' education then fully transit in using the majority language (English) when they reach higher levels. Former colonized countries enforced this language education system to enable the use of the colonial language (Garcia, O. & Woodley, H., 2015).

The traditional perspective of regarding 'bilingual education' as *monoglossic* shifted to a new perspective where 'bilingual education' is now viewed as *heteroglossic*. With the fast interconnection of different cultures across the globe increased by the movement of globalization, internationalization, technological enhancement, and migration, bilingual education considers situations where students are multi-lingual; where students want to learn a second or a third language; and where students with different first languages learn in the same class. With many factors affecting the development of a bilingual education program in the context of where it is being utilized, perhaps, the most recent description of its evolution called, "dynamic *bi/plurilingual education*" as introduced by Garcia and Kleifgen in 2010, and developed by Garcia and Sylvan in 2011 where students' preferences of what language to learn better are given utmost importance in the learning process. Interestingly, the concept of "*translanguaging*" came to view where both teachers and students are using one language in instruction, but then students are allowed to use other languages in the process (researching, discussions, etc.) to produce work.

With these different "innovations" emanating from the concept of bilingual education, I believe that defining its characteristics and nature depends on the context of where will it be used, and how it will be implemented putting the beneficiaries as the priority. Let's take Singapore as an example. Its bilingual education program started from the government's bilingual policy to address the various socio-cultural groups with different first languages. Singapore is shared by three distinct and intertwined cultures: Chinese (77%), Malay (15%), and Indian (7%), and many other 'minority' groups that comprise a highly diverse society. In fact, Singapore has four official languages, and English is regarded as its 'neutral' working language. Singapore's bilingual policy made English as its official language, and its bilingual education program uses

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English and the first language of students. The idea is for students to learn English to acquire more knowledge and skills while preserving their "mother tongue" (Dixon, 2005).

In 2018, the Ministry of Education of Taiwan launched the planning and implementation of the "bilingualization" of the current educational system as part of the bigger goal of Taiwan government to 'bilingualize' the country by 2030. In its news article, five polices were provided:

> "*…1. Adopt a dynamic teaching approach with focus on daily English use, 2. expand human resources required for English education, 3. make effective use of digital technology and promote individualized learning, 4. accelerate the internationalization of the educational system, and 5. relax current regulations to allow for flexible mechanisms*…(p.1)."

These policies come with guidelines in implementing them. One of them is on teacher training where 18 teacher training universities will take part in the plan, and it is expected that 2,000 teachers will start teaching in 2022; 3,000 teachers in 2026; and 4,000 teachers in 2030. As of this writing, the creation of some pertinent laws to support the fourth and fifth measures is an on-going discussion among policy makers and lawmakers.

This government's policy brings teachers to reform their usual ways in teaching as they are now directed to realign the curriculum and instruction to these three expectations which I think are the starting point of coming up with action plans that can be implemented and evaluated at the school level: promotion of the Content and Language Integrated Learning (CLIL); implementation of the Teaching English in English (TEIE); and promotion of English for Specific Purposes (ESP). This paper highlights some recent literatures that tackle these three expectations.

The Content and Language Integrated Learning (CLIL)

The Content and Language Integrated Learning (CLIL) as a concept emerged in the 1990s, and the term was coined in 1994 in Europe. It was about teaching and learning not only language but also content, and one thing that all practitioners agree on is that it is "context orientated" (Canado, 2011). Since then it has always been associated to bilingual education programs across the globe; however, some educators claimed that the CLIL has evolved more than as a trend in foreign language teaching. Klimova (2012) refuted the claim that content teachers get more burden than language teachers as she pointed out, with certainty, that "language teachers become the CLIL specialists." It is even for this reason that their preparation in using the method is highly needed.

McDougald (2016) pointed out four challenges in implementing the CLIL: (1) opposition to language teaching by subject teachers, (2) experimental CLIL programs, (3) SLA skills needed by subject content teachers, and (4) lack of CLIL teacher-training programs. Consequently, he also provided some suggestions in easing the difficulty of implementing it: encourage

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collaboration and teamwork between content and language teachers; and document its outcome starting from the classroom level up to the school level. As the CLIL continues to gain its popularity, there are even more concerns that need further investigation on materials, assessment, and effectiveness to learning.

Yang (2018) revealed that the Content and Language Integrated Learning (CLIL) education has only been implemented at the tertiary level in Taiwan in 2011, but he recommended the introduction of the CLIL approach in secondary or elementary schools. Furthermore, he evaluated the CLIL materials used in one of the universities in Taiwan. One of the findings revealed that students' high school English proficiency and previous secondary school major significantly affected how they perceived the materials used in their university studies. In 2012, Yang and Gosling found some concerns of university students about using the method relating to linguistic competence, content knowledge, NS vs NNS, use of L1 Chinese, and language support. What does these findings imply? I think that the CLIL approach used in Taiwan universities can yield better results if students in the primary and secondary level are gradually exposed to it. The government's bilingual education program is very timely if not long overdue. With its full implementation, I assume, in 2022 at the primary and secondary level, say, starting with grade 1 and grade 7, current primary and junior high school teachers should be prepared to handle them three years from now. Those preparatory years for transition maybe enough, but at this point, it is those current primary and junior high teachers who need all the support that they can get.

Teaching English in English (TEIE)

Chen and Tsai (2012) noted that English is categorized as a foreign language (EFL) in Taiwan; only about 2–4% of the total population use English on a daily basis. Historically, they explained that formal English instruction started in 1968 although English learning can be dated back in the early 19th century. Further reforms were made in 1968, 1993, 1994, 1995, and 2001. The reforms implemented in 2001 were expected to show results in 2008. After ten years, the Ministry of Education created its most recent advocacy emphasizing on making Taiwan a bilingual country which is viewed as a big step forward. Implementing one of the measures which is "teaching English in English" is not that as easy as it looks as there are not just some pedagogical and linguistic preparations needed, but there are also some individual empowerment and professional development that the government should be closely paying attention to.

Liao (2017) suggested that there is a need for Taiwanese English teachers to "find their strengths to establish their identities as legitimate English educators." Some of the reasons why many Taiwanese English teachers lack the confidence of using English are due to the perceived lack of "authenticity" in using English, their fear of committing errors, and the preference of parents that their children should be taught by a native English speaker or a Taiwanese English teacher who was educated and had experienced using English in an English-speaking environment. Furthermore, "*English language proficiency affects their confidence and how they see themselves professionally.*" Yet again, more teacher training and in-service professional development are required to help teachers start owning the English language. What does

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"owning the English language" exactly mean? Holliday (2005) as cited by Liao (2017) encouraged English teachers who are non-native English speakers to motivate themselves in continuously using English as "*English is now international and its ownership is shifted to whoever wished to use it rather than to people in specific geographic locations."*

It was also discovered that the problems in teaching English in junior high schools do not necessarily stem from the Taiwanese English teachers' ability to use English in the classroom. Lin (2015) pointed out that the *'discontinuity in styles of pedagogy from elementary to junior high levels'* affects not just students' motivation to learn English, but the necessity of Taiwanese English teachers in junior high school to use Mandarin in teaching grammar and vocabulary to their students. It appears that there is indeed a need to do so to enable their students to learn "the rules" of the language faster for exam purposes. The solutions in narrowing this gap can be a re-evaluation of the enforced pedagogy, competencies, and assessments of the entire program from the primary up to the secondary level, or arbitrarily school-based adjustments on the use of 'best practices' in teaching English so that students will not regard English merely as another subject and at the same time provide the opportunity for teachers to "teach English in English."

English for Specific Purposes (ESP)

While the English for Specific Purposes (ESP) is best used in vocational, college and university curriculum, I believe that it should be considered in senior high schools' electives and subjects design specially to grade 11 and 12 students. What is ESP?

Cited by Donesh-Jezo (2012), Hutchinson and Waters (1987, p. 19) define ESP as *"an approach to language learning which is based on learner need. The foundation of all ESP is the simple question: Why does the learner need to learn a foreign language? ... ESP, then, is an approach to language teaching in which all decisions as to content and method are based on the learner's reason for learning."* Donesh-Jezo re-echoed the purpose of ESP which is to pinpoint the exact needs of the learners in using the foreign language in their future careers so they can acquire the specific linguistic, communicative, discourse, content, situations, and other preparations.

Su (n.d.) researched on English for Specific Purposes (ESP) in Technological and Vocational Higher Education in Taiwan, and she highlighted some general concerns that affect the implementation of ESP-based courses, and their solutions. First, students' insufficient language skill is one of the obstacles and main factor of the inefficiency of ESP; to deal with the problem, "*ESP practitioners should reconsider the goals, objectives as well as the course design*." Second, there is a lack of qualified ESP instructors in Taiwan; two recommendations were discussed in the study: "*(1) The universities in Taiwan should take positive action of developing a systematic teacher education program for ESP, (2) to encourage the in service English teachers and subject teachers to foster their second professional specialty."* The work of Tsao, Wei, and Fang (2008) resulted to some remedies in dealing with both students and teachers' concerns.

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According to the authors, "*ESP teachers should select materials that are less specialized in content knowledge but still related to the learners' fields of study or work."*

Despite of these numerous issues on the implementation of the ESP in vocational schools, colleges, and universities, it is clear, however, that there is a positive response from the students and teachers towards it. Essentially, whatever ELT approaches that Taiwan enforce, we can safely conclude that it is the preparation of those involved who need to be supported: students and teachers.

The Challenges of a Bilingual Teacher and a CLIL Specialist

The assumption is that a bilingual teacher doesn't necessarily refer to an EFL/ESL teacher alone. It is a role that both content and language teachers need to play in helping to address the challenges of implementing the 'bilingualization' policy of the government. On the other hand, EFL/ESL teachers should start taking baby steps in transforming their roles as CLIL specialists. This is not an easy commitment, but it is doable although not in a fast-paced mode. Before I'll tackle the challenges of a bilingual teacher and a CLIL specialist, it is extremely important to keep on re-echoing the phenomena that Taiwanese teachers and students (including the entire community) are in the process of owning the English language as their own. They need to realize that they are not strictly bound to follow how native English speakers and other non-native English speakers use the language. While they can learn from them, there comes a time when English will be *nativized* in Taiwan. I will discuss the topic at hand by categorizing the challenges and their intervention plans into two: *internal and external attributes.*

The internal attributes are identified based on INDIVIDUAL and PROFESSIONAL challenges and preparations that both bilingual teacher and CLIL specialist need to focus on; meanwhile the external attributes are explained based on SOCIAL and EDUCATIONAL factors. The diagram illustrates the model.

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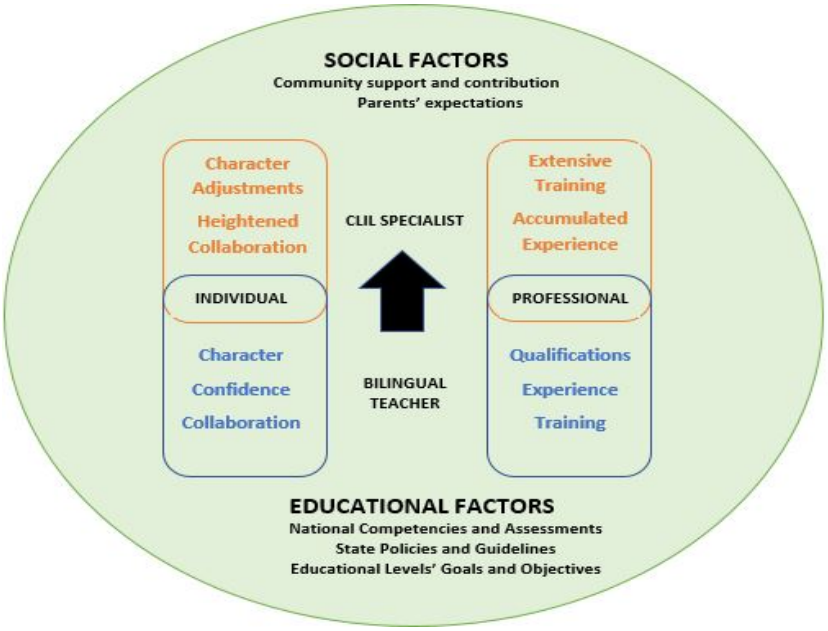

Figure 1 The Bilingual Teacher and CLIL Specialist Model

The Internal Attributes: Individual and Professional Challenges and Preparations

Both bilingual teacher and CLIL specialist have to go through some individual and professional transformations in order to carry out their roles and do their responsibilities effectively. Note that the individual attributes: character, confidence, and collaboration at the bilingual teacher level; and character adjustments, and heightened collaboration for the CLIL specialist are VALUES ORIENTED. On the other hand, the professional attributes: qualifications, experience, and training for the bilingual teacher; and extensive training, and accumulated experience at the level of the CLIL specialist are SKILLS ORIENTED. Both orientations are progressive and dynamic which means a CLIL specialist can truly become one if he or she first undergoes the transformations needed for a bilingual teacher. Simply stated, one can't become an effective CLIL specialist if he or she has never been a bilingual teacher. What I would really like to emphasize in this section is to discuss the challenges and preparations that teachers, no matter what their roles are in their respective schools, who are part of the bilingual education reform need to cope up with.

A teacher's character who is open-minded, flexible, and humble usually takes part proactively in the process of any reformation. Nothing can be achieved if plans are not implemented, and no significant positive changes are expected if the implementer (the teacher) does not put his heart into it. These personal struggles and demotivation are not something new. In our teaching career, we were all directed to try different ways than what we usually do in the classroom, but putting them into practice is challenging. Almost always, research studies point out the lack of interest, the fear of stepping out from comfort zones, and the act of resistance for accepting changes are the issues confronting the individual teacher. One of the preparations that teachers especially the seasoned teachers need to do a lot more is to learn the art of self-reflection and reflective teaching. Without it, we will be cultivating dominant teachers who

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regard their knowledge and skills as superior from the rest. While self-reflections are supposedly done by the individual teacher alone, it is with the best interest of the school to provide support through one-on-one discussions and consultations either with an immediate superior or an outside help from an expert.

The lack of confidence of using English as a medium of instruction emanates not necessarily from the lack of training but due to the fear of committing errors or not being "native" enough. While preparation (yet again) is the key to boost our confidence, I would like to reiterate that non-native English speakers use English differently and while our "English" is not perfect, we have to own the language. It means that we will commit errors in the process, but we can only better ourselves by improving our use of the English language. There are different possible ways that we can do on our own to make our English comprehensible to our learners. We don't want to be using English like a native speaker in the classroom, for instance, using idioms that our learners have no idea about. As a bilingual teacher, we have an advantage of teaching our students because we can explain some difficult vocabularies, idioms, and concepts in our first language. Just like our learners who gradually become more English proficient, bilingual teachers need to start from somewhere to help themselves develop their second language skills…and it starts from not getting intimated in using English.

The willingness to collaborate to complete a task is intrapersonal. It always starts from the attitude of the bilingual teacher towards collaboration. One of the foreseen challenges of a bilingual teacher is working with either the content teacher or the language teacher which now become interpersonal. Research findings show that the selection and design of learning materials should be a collaborative effort between the content teacher, and the language teacher. In fact, in designing ESP-based courses, students, employees, and employers should take part of the process. No collaboration takes place when one is unwilling to do it. The 'ideal' character of a bilingual teacher and a CLIL specialist is to be open minded. I truly believe that if we are willing to learn, we have to make compromises on our own 'philosophy' towards teaching. It is always a good start to collaborate with teachers whom we are comfortable talking and dealing with until we feel ready to work closely with the rest of the teachers.

The professional attributes of a bilingual teacher talk about his qualifications, experience, and training. Past researches in Taiwan's context concluded that there appears a lack of qualifications, experience, and training of bilingual teachers including university ESP instructors in using English in the classroom. The solution to this problem is found in the problem: get qualified, get more experience, and get more training. One research recommended that universities with teacher training institutes should offer bilingual education and CLIL diplomas. That is something that I definitely agree on. Subject teachers who are about to be transformed as bilingual teachers should be in sync in terms of role clarity, pedagogy and the use of 'best practices,' assessment, and materials development. Universities or teacher training institutes can set the standards as basis for further program evaluation.

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Getting more experience in using English in the classroom can be arranged by the bilingual teacher himself. When teachers design learning opportunities that allow the use of English actively, say, in speaking English, there is a greater chance of improving speaking communication skills. Learning English from the beginning to emerging levels, as many ESL practitioners and educators agree, focuses more on skill development rather than knowledge acquisition until they have better control of the target language. In other words, like any other skill-getting and skill-learning subjects, it takes time to master a set of skills. When we keep on practicing, it only makes our skill better.

The External Attributes: Social and Educational Factors

There are some external factors that affect our motivation in implementing the CLIL, the TIEI, and ESP at our levels. These are social and educational elements that we don't have a direct control of. With social factors, they are correlated with the perceptions of the community and the parents; meanwhile, educational factors are the executive decisions from the Ministry of Education on educational plans, policies, and guidelines that teachers have to follow whether we are teaching in a public or private school.

How the community uses English is a determining factor on the extent of teaching English. Taiwan at this stage uses English as a Foreign Language: people use English only when they are in a situation when they have to use English to communicate. With EFL students, they only learn and use English in the classroom then they revert in using their first language when they are outside the classroom. This characterizes, at present, how English is also taught in most public and private schools. With its bilingual policy, Taiwan is stepping the first stages of making the country as a whole an English as Second Language users. The attempt to make English as an Official Language can coincide with the ESL framework but it requires double effort for the entire community. How can we characterize a country that uses English as a Second Language? Or English as an Official Language?

English as a second language is the stage when people (as a community) uses English at some point in their daily conversations or professional discussions. We can say that they have better control over the second language to the extent that they have already "*owned the language*." It means that English has been *nativized* or the way they use English is localized that they can be distinguished and validated different from the "standard" English of British and Americans. Neighboring countries like Singapore, Philippines, Malaysians, and India have reached this stage of *nativization* of English. What makes English as an Official Language is when a country uses it in technical fields of business communication, law formulation and litigation, scientific and academic journals, literature, music, and more. In other words, people address formal and technical settings with the use of English. Thus, we expect that all written and spoken forms are in English that can be qualified as 'standard' yet 'nativized.'

Generally speaking, the community support and contribution to the country's bilingual policy is an important indicator how its implementation is progressing, and the school plays an

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important role in it. I believe that many local English teachers at this point understand their EFL roles and the extent of the implementation of the so-called, "Teach English in English" measure. For now, they can only teach English as a foreign language and when the right time comes, to teach English as a second language. The proper timing to intensify the teaching and learning of English as a second language is when the community does its part (e.g. signs are written both in first and second English, professional and skilled workers partly use English in communicating, more locals in tourist areas attempt to speak English, etc.). The point of this brief introductions of this second language phenomena and realities is that local English teachers have no other options, but to become the role models to affect change at least in the educational landscape of their respective countries.

In a general point of view, another social factor that needs to be addressed is the perception and expectation of some 'elitist' parents. It is understandable that some parents have the notion that for English learning to be effective among students, English should be taught by a native-English speaker or a local teacher who was educated abroad or lived in an English-speaking country. In a few cases, parents' expectation can result to stigma which leads to some local English teachers use their first language to teach English. There are considerable accounts, however, that local teachers take it as a challenge. They painstakingly improve their communication skills through individual and professional means in this way they can be perceived better by parents. There is no easy way to change one's perception, but to demonstrate how they are capable of improving to get accepted at a certain degree. I believe that when parents are exposed to more locals who speak English in any way possible, they will reach the stage of acceptance.

Globally, EFL teachers are also caught in between expectations and reality from three educational factors: national competency and assessment, policies and guidelines, and alignment of educational goals and objectives of basic, secondary and tertiary education. Let me explain these factors in a situation. English as a Foreign Language teachers rely on national competencies (broad learning outcomes) and assessments (standard national examinations) as they are often evaluated how well they are in teaching based on evidences of teaching that achieve the country's expected learning outcomes, and the result of the passing rate of their students in a national standard test. Take for instance the situation in junior high schools before the implementation of the "Teach English in English." When learning and assessment standards weigh grammar (structure) higher, naturally, any EFL teacher will use the first language to explain complex English forms. They are even more compelled to focus on teaching structure as primary education adheres to learning English through a fun and relaxed way which is a different pedagogical approach in junior high. Then here comes the expectation of the bilingual policy which aimed at improving students' English proficiency through more active language skills learning like speaking and writing, and not to mention the IELTS or TOEFL exams required by some universities. Many students resort to attending cram schools or language centers to meet the university requirements, and they do have stronger English skills compared to those who are unable to get language learning support outside school. Even in the implementation of the ESP

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courses or the use of English as a Medium of Instruction in universities suffer from the lack of preparation of students who are not proficient enough. Suffice to say that there is a concern on the lack of alignment and balance from the competencies, pedagogical approaches, and assessments in all three levels: basic, secondary, and tertiary. Even if we argue that such is not the case, both EFL teachers and learners still take a lot of pressure of meeting the educational demands.

In conclusion, Taiwan has set up good plans in training future teachers to tackle the role of a bilingual teacher or a CLIL specialist, and they will be deployed to actual teaching in 2022. However, unless some changes in the competencies, assessments, policies, guidelines, and goals and objectives are made that affect actual teaching and learning of English as a foreign language or as a second language, the situation might remain the same with the incoming first batch of newly-trained teachers. More importantly, with only two years remaining, what specific plans does the Ministry of Education intend to implement for the current teachers?

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ABEL M. CADIAS, LPT, PhD

About the lecturer: Dr. Abel Cadias specializes in curriculum and instruction, administration and supervision, and international education. He has been teaching and doing some administrative work at different school levels in various educational programs for more than 20 years. He currently works at the Affiliated International High School of National Chengchi University.

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